

In the Void of What We Were

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6:00 A.M. The alarm cut through the silence like something that had no patience for dreams.

Bás lay still for a moment before moving, not from exhaustion, but from habit. He did this every morning: a few seconds in which he simply existed without agenda. The ceiling above him was white and blank, and he let his eyes rest on it the way other people might stare at the ocean. Then he sat up.

His feet found the cold floor. The sensation grounded him, the way it always did. He stood at his full height, tall, lean, the kind of frame that looks carved rather than grown, and breathed in the particular silence of the base before it woke up. There was something almost sacred about it. The machinery dormant. The corridors empty. The world not yet demanding anything from him.

He padded to the bathroom and turned on the tap, watching water pool in the basin. When he cupped it in both hands and pressed it to his face, he held it there a moment longer than necessary. The cold traveled through his skin and something inside him, some tight, coiled thing, loosened, just slightly. In the mirror, green eyes looked back at him. He studied them with the neutral expression of a man examining evidence. They didn't give much away. He'd learned that early.

On the hook beside the mirror hung his mask, painted metal, skull-faced, worn smooth at the edges from years of use. Most people who saw it assumed it was armor, or intimidation. It was neither, really. It was just his. A part of him he hadn't had to explain in a long time. He took it carefully, almost tenderly, and carried it with him out into the corridor.

The mess hall hit him with noise before he reached the door.

He recognized the laughter first. Zephyr's laugh was the kind that didn't ask permission, it just arrived, filling whatever space it found, dragging people along with it whether they wanted to go or not. Bás paused for just a moment in the doorway, watching.

Zephyr held court at a table near the windows, leaning back in his chair with the comfortable authority of someone who had long since decided the world was a stage and he had no intention of standing in the wings. His outfit today was a spectacular offense against subtlety, electric blue and gold, with accents that seemed to catch light that wasn't there. Around him, three junior agents were laughing at something he'd said, or perhaps at him, and Zephyr accepted both interpretations equally.

Bás went to the food line. He selected what he always selected: a slice of whole-grain bread, a glass of water, a small bowl of fruit that someone had cut up that morning. He stood for a moment with the tray in his hands, looking at it.

Zephyr had once called it a "ritual of deprivation." Bás didn't think of it that way. He thought of it as precision, keeping the body functional without sentiment.

He crossed the room and sat down beside Zephyr without announcement. The two didn't need announcement. Zephyr glanced over, clocked the tray, and his grin spread wide.

"Bás. My friend. My brooding, magnificent friend." He gestured at the tray with theatrical dismay. "What is this? What are you feeding yourself? A water and three grapes? Are you becoming a monk? Have I missed the ceremony?"

Bás picked up a slice of apple and looked at it with the seriousness of a man being asked to explain his entire philosophy. "It keeps me functional."

"It keeps you haunted," Zephyr corrected, pouring himself another glass of something orange and suspiciously bright. "You eat like someone who has forgotten that food is also a pleasure. Look at my plate. Look at the colors. I am nourishing my soul, Bás. My actual soul."

"Your plate looks like a carnival exploded."

Zephyr pointed a fork at him triumphantly. "Yes. And carnivals are wonderful."

Something shifted in Bás's expression, not quite a smile, but the suggestion of one, the shadow a smile leaves behind. Zephyr caught it immediately, the way he always caught things Bás tried to hide. It was one of the more infuriating things about him.

"Keep talking," Bás said, biting into the apple. "Maybe by the end of breakfast you'll convince me that life is worth living for the food."

"That is a promise I will dedicate my entire career to keeping."

They sat together in the particular ease of people who have shared enough danger to stop performing around each other. The morning moved around them, the low

hum of conversation, the scrape of chairs, the distant smell of coffee. Bás didn't drink coffee. Zephyr had four cups.

The intercom interrupted them.

Benny's voice, slightly too loud as always, requested their presence in his office immediately. Zephyr stood up with the enthusiasm of someone who had been waiting for exactly this kind of summons. Bás rose more slowly, setting down his half-eaten apple with something that might have been reluctance, though he would have denied it.

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They walked the corridors side by side, and Bás found himself, not for the first time, thinking about how strange it was to have a partner. He had not always had one. There had been years of working alone, years of relying on nothing but his own precision and the cold comfort of preparation. Zephyr had arrived in his life like weather, sudden, overwhelming, impossible to ignore. Somehow, the arrangement had held.

"Benny called us both," Zephyr observed, as if narrating a documentary about their own lives. "That's either very good or very catastrophic."

"With Benny, those are often the same thing."

Zephyr laughed. It echoed in the corridor. Two passing agents looked up from their tablets and smiled without quite knowing why, infected by something they couldn't name.

Bás watched this happen and felt, as he sometimes did, a complicated sort of gratitude he didn't have words for.

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Benny's office was a monument to the idea that organization was a myth invented by people with too little imagination.

Every surface hosted something improbable. The shelves were crammed with artifacts, devices, scrolls, and what appeared to be a collection of decorative eggs that occasionally glowed. Papers were stacked with the aggressive optimism of someone who believed they would eventually be read. At the center of the desk, an old, battered teddy bear named Chuckles sat with the serene authority of a judge, one eye slightly looser than the other, apparently overseeing everything.

Benny himself was behind the desk, engaged in what looked like an experiment involving three biscuits suspended in midair. He looked up when they entered with the expression of a man who is delighted by absolutely everything.

"Bás! Zephyr! My favorite instruments of controlled chaos!"

"Benny," Bás said, taking in the room with a slow sweep of his eyes. "I'd ask what you're doing, but I've decided it's better not to know."

"Wise. Very wise." Benny set the biscuits down, they descended at roughly normal gravity, which was almost more unsettling. "Sit, please. Or stand. Or hover, if you've developed that capability and haven't told me."

Zephyr dropped into the nearest chair with the boneless ease of a man immune to furniture's structural limitations. Bás remained standing. He always remained standing in Benny's office. It felt safer, somehow, to be able to move.

Benny folded his hands on the desk. His expression shifted, not dramatically, but enough. The theater fell away and something beneath it emerged, something older and more serious. Bás recognized this version of Benny. This was the version that had sent him to places from which people sometimes didn't come back.

"This one is different," Benny said.

The folder he placed on the desk was thick, worn at the edges from handling. Bás crossed the room and picked it up. He opened it and began reading with the focused silence of someone disassembling a mechanism.

On the first page was a photograph.

The figure in it was massive, encased in black armor that looked less manufactured than grown, organic and deliberate, fitted to a body that suggested both engineering and something older. Red lights burned through the visor of a helmet designed to unsettle. And the sword at the figure's side, Yoru, the dossier named it, pulsed with a soft, rose-pink luminescence that looked completely wrong against the darkness around it.

Zephyr leaned over and let out a low, slow whistle. "He looks like what happens when a samurai and a nightmare have a child."

"His name is Kazran Kurokai," Benny said. "Known as Voidblade. Last surviving member of a warrior clan that was destroyed fourteen years ago." A pause. "He destroyed most of the people responsible. The rest he's working through."

Silence.

Bás turned a page. Then another. He read carefully, the way he did everything. "The sword," he said finally. "It can cut across physical and spiritual planes simultaneously."

"So they say."

"Who are 'they'?"

"People who survived encounters with it. There aren't many."

Zephyr had gone quiet in a way that was unusual for him. He was looking at the photograph with an expression Bás recognized, the one Zephyr wore when he was processing something that made him uneasy and trying not to show it. They'd

worked together long enough that Bás could read the performance beneath the performance.

"Japan," Bás said.

"Japan," Benny confirmed. "A rural area north of a small village outside Osaka. There's a forest, and inside it, a shrine that's been abandoned for decades. Kazran has been using it as a base. Our intelligence suggests he's planning something significant." He stroked Chuckles absently. "Our contact in the region is a man named Tanaka. Reliable, practical, not someone who will be able to help you if things go badly. You'll be largely on your own."

"Cover?" Bás asked.

"Cultural researchers. I've prepared documents. They're excellent." A small, proud smile. "I've also arranged accommodation that doesn't smell like military hardware, which I feel you both underappreciate."

Zephyr managed to find his grin again, though it was smaller than usual. "Japan. I've wanted to go to Japan."

"Don't enjoy it too much," Bás said, closing the folder. He tucked it under his arm. "When do we leave?"

"This evening." Benny looked at him with something that might have been concern, filtered through layers of eccentricity. "Bás. Read the full dossier. Particularly the section on his history. It matters."

Bás held the man's gaze for a moment. Then he nodded once and left.

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The journey took sixteen hours.

Zephyr spent a significant portion of it talking to a flight attendant about the merits of various noodle dishes, then fell asleep somewhere over the Pacific with

his head at an angle that should have caused neck damage. Bás sat upright in the seat beside him and read.

He read the dossier three times. By the third pass, the facts had arranged themselves into something he could almost understand. A clan of warriors, old lineage, strict code, fierce pride. A political dispute that escalated. A night, fourteen years ago, when someone decided the clan was an inconvenience. Men sent with weapons and instructions. A boy who was not supposed to survive.

He did survive.

Bás sat with that for a while, the cabin dark around him, Zephyr's breathing slow and even beside him. He thought about boys who were not supposed to survive. He thought about what it cost, and what it made you, and whether there was a meaningful difference between the person you'd been before and the person who crawled out of the wreckage wearing the same name.

He didn't sleep.

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The village was everything the dossier hadn't prepared him for.

It was quiet in a way cities never are, not the absence of sound but the presence of a different kind of it. Wind through pine trees. The distant percussion of a woodpecker. The creak of an old wooden sign outside a shop that sold things wrapped in paper. Bás stood on the gravel path outside their accommodation and breathed it in and felt something he couldn't immediately name.

Zephyr was already three meters ahead of him, spinning in a slow circle with his arms out, face turned up to the pale morning sky.

"This is beautiful," he said. Not loudly. It was just a fact, stated as gently as he was capable of. "Bás. Look at this."

"I'm looking."

"No, I mean actually look. Stop reading the dossier with your eyes and look at what's actually in front of you."

Bás looked. Pine hills rolling up behind the village. A small shrine visible through a break in the buildings, its orange torii gate brilliant against the grey-green forest. A cat sitting on a wall, watching them with the serene indifference of creatures who have long understood they owe humans nothing.

"It's beautiful," he agreed.

Zephyr glanced back at him, surprised, then turned away quickly so Bás wouldn't see his expression. He failed.

Tanaka found them an hour later, a compact, quiet man in his fifties who had the look of someone who had learned patience through necessity rather than temperament. He briefed them in the genkan of their accommodation, speaking in low, precise English, his hands still in his lap.

Kazran had been seen near the northern shrine three days ago. There had been no sightings since, but the forest rangers who usually walked that area had quietly stopped walking it. The shrine was ancient, used for ceremonies that predated record-keeping, abandoned formally a century ago. The kind of place that collected its own gravity.

"He's not there by accident," Bás said.

"No," Tanaka agreed. "I don't think he does anything by accident."

After Tanaka left, they prepared in silence. Checked equipment. Bás read specific sections of the dossier again while Zephyr stretched on the tatami floor with methodical, unhurried thoroughness. They'd done this enough times that the ritual had its own rhythm. When Zephyr finished, he sat cross-legged and looked at Bás.

"You're quieter than usual."

"I'm thinking."

"I can tell. You get a specific quality of silence when you're actually worried about something." Zephyr paused. "The dossier. His history."

"He's not irrational," Bás said. "That's the problem. Everything he's done follows a logic. A terrible one, but coherent."

Zephyr nodded slowly. "So talking to him might work."

"It might." Bás closed the dossier. "It might not."

They looked at each other across the quiet room, the tatami beneath them, the sound of the village outside the window, ordinary and indifferent to what they were about to do.

"Izakaya when we're done," Zephyr said. "Real food. You and me."

Bás considered this. "Yes," he said. "All right."

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The forest was different when you were inside it.

From the village it had looked peaceful, just trees, just hills, just the normal architecture of a Japanese countryside in autumn. Inside, under the canopy, the light changed. It came in pieces, fractured by branches, and everything it touched looked provisional. The path narrowed. The air cooled. Bás noted the silence, not peaceful silence, but watchful. The birds had stopped.

They walked without speaking for a while. The undergrowth was thick on either side, ferns brushing against the path. Somewhere above them, something moved through the canopy and was still again.

Zephyr spoke first. "Remember that job in Mexico? The man who could control volcanic activity?" He gestured in the air, reconstructing the memory. "You talked to him for forty minutes. Forty minutes, Bás. I nearly fell asleep in the rafters."

"It worked."

"It worked because he respected you. You'd done your reading. You understood him." A pause. "You always understand them. That's your thing."

"You knocked down an entire wall."

"For atmosphere. It was a confidence-building exercise." But Zephyr's tone had shifted. "I mean it, though. I've seen a lot of people in this work who see an enemy and just see an enemy. You see the person." He glanced sideways. "I think that's why it costs you more."

Bás walked several steps before responding. "It's just preparation. If you understand who someone is, you have more options."

"Right." Zephyr's voice was quiet. "And if it can't be talked through, if it has to go the other way, that costs you more too. I've seen your face after. I don't have a lot of lines I won't cross, but you've got them everywhere, and they're not comfortable."

Bás stopped walking.

Zephyr stopped too, a step ahead, and turned around.

"I learned something about the things we carry," Bás said carefully. "A long time ago, in a situation I don't discuss. I learned that you can either let the weight of it make you careful, or you can let it make you hard. I chose careful. It's not comfortable. But hard would have been worse."

Zephyr held his gaze for a moment, then nodded once, not casually, but with a solemnity he rarely showed. "Yeah," he said. "I know."

They walked on.

The shrine appeared between the trees without ceremony, simply there, where path became clearing and clearing held an old wooden structure that had been letting time happen to it for longer than either of them had been alive. Moss

covered the lower walls. The steps leading to the entrance were cracked, vegetation pushing through the gaps with the patient insistence of things that have no deadlines. One of the doors hung open, darkness visible beyond it.

Bás felt the back of his neck tighten.

"The air is different here," Zephyr said, almost to himself. His voice had shed the lightness completely. This was the other Zephyr, the one underneath, the one that had survived things he also didn't discuss.

"Yes," Bás said. "Stay close."

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Inside, the darkness was not simply the absence of light, it had texture, substance, the quality of something that had been undisturbed long enough to become a presence in itself. Bás moved slowly, letting his eyes adjust. The torchlight they carried pushed weakly at the edges of the space and found the walls covered in moss, in graffiti that might have been decades old, in markings that predated everything.

The central room was larger than the exterior suggested. An altar stood at its center, and on the altar were papers.

Lots of papers.

Bás crossed the room and picked up the nearest one. He read two lines and stopped. He read them again.

"Zephyr."

Zephyr appeared at his shoulder. He took the paper, scanned it, and put it down carefully. He picked up another. Then another.

"These are dossiers," he said. "On us." His voice had gone flat and controlled. "These are our dossiers. These are things that aren't supposed to exist in one place."

Bás was already reading. His own file. His full name, which he never used. His history, laid out in neat, precise handwriting. Dates. Places. Things he had lost. Things that had been done. A boy who was not supposed to survive, and what had been made of him in the years since.

He set the paper down. He was aware, distantly, that his hands were very steady. He focused on that, on the steadiness of his hands.

"He knows us," he said. "Not our operational profiles. Us."

The metallic crash behind them was not loud, but in that silence it detonated like a signal.

They moved together without discussion, backs together, facing the dark corners of the room. Bás let the shadows come to him, felt them at the edges of his awareness, familiar as old tools. Zephyr's hands were already raised, ready.

Nothing moved. For seven seconds, nothing moved.

Then the darkness at the far end of the room arranged itself differently.

Kazran stepped forward.

He was larger in reality than in photographs. The armor caught what little light existed and gave none of it back. The red glow from his visor was steady, calm, unhurried. He moved like someone who had never in his life needed to rush toward anything, because everything he wanted had always, eventually, come to him.

He looked at them for a long moment.

Then he moved.

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What Bás would remember later was not the force of it, though the force was extraordinary, but the precision. Kazran chose Zephyr first, not because Zephyr was the greater threat in that moment, but because Zephyr was the one more likely to interfere with conversation. The energy he released struck with the exact minimum force required to remove Zephyr from the equation without finishing him. It was the attack of someone who had calculated everything in advance.

Zephyr hit the wall hard enough to crack the stone. He slid down it and stayed down, stunned.

And then it was just the two of them.

Bás and Kazran, in the weak light of a ruined shrine, surrounded by papers that documented what both of them had survived.

The silence lasted long enough that Bás counted his own heartbeats. He made himself count them slowly.

"You didn't have to do that," he said.

Kazran tilted his head. The gesture was almost human. "He would have interrupted."

"He does that. It's not always a disadvantage." Bás held very still. "I've read about you. Not just the reports, the history. I understand what happened to your clan."

Something in Kazran's stance shifted. Infinitesimal, but there.

"Understanding," the man said. His voice, processed through the helmet, had a quality like a sound heard underwater, recognizable but wrong. "You think understanding changes anything."

"I think it changes what's possible." Bás took one careful step forward. "I know what it is to carry something that doesn't fit inside you properly. Something that

takes up more space than you have. I know what happens when that weight becomes the reason for everything." He paused. "I've stood where you're standing. The logic of it is seductive. Everything reduced to a single purpose."

"And you chose differently."

"I chose differently."

Kazran was quiet for a moment. The sword at his side, Yoru, pulsed faintly, that soft wrong rose light. When he spoke again, it was with a precision that suggested the words had been held for a long time.

"My clan had a code. Every death honored. Every wrong answered. Justice is not revenge, it is acknowledgment. The acknowledgment that what was taken mattered." A pause. "They took my entire world and called it politics. I am acknowledging it."

"I know," Bás said. "I know that's what it is to you. And the people who ordered what happened to your clan, some of them deserved exactly what you gave them." He met the red glow of the visor with his own steady green. "But you've gone past them now. The people you're moving toward next, they're not the ones who made the decision."

Silence.

"They profited from it," Kazran said.

"Yes. That's true. But--"

Yoru rose.

Not a decision, Bás understood, a reflex. The argument had gotten too close to something, had pressed on a wound that had been open too long, and Kazran had not made a choice so much as simply moved, the way an injured animal moves when the pain becomes sudden.

Bás stepped back and let the shadows take him.

What followed was not elegant.

Combat with someone like Kazran was never elegant, it was a sustained argument conducted in movement, each exchange a sentence in a conversation that both parties were trying to finish. Bás worked the edges, used the darkness, let Zephyr, recovered, upright, and deeply displeased, provide the blunt force that he lacked. They found a rhythm, the same rhythm they always found, the one that required no discussion. Zephyr drew the attention. Bás found the spaces.

Kazran was extraordinary. Bás acknowledged this without drama. The man moved through shadows the way Bás did, which was disorienting, meeting a version of your own strategy reflected back at you, filtered through a different life. When Kazran struck it was always with economy, never wasted motion, never cruelty beyond what was necessary.

He was not a monster. That was the complicated thing. He was a man who had decided, after fourteen years of surviving an atrocity, that nothing else remained.

Bás used an illusion, pulled a fear from Kazran's past and placed it between them like an object. He hadn't wanted to. It felt like a violation, reaching into someone's worst memories and using them as a weapon. But Kazran had been about to remove Zephyr's ability to stand, and Bás had made his choice.

The distraction lasted three seconds.

Zephyr used them.

The impact sent Kazran through a wall of the shrine. Stone and old wood showered the floor. For a moment, nothing moved in the dust.

Then Bás found the gap in the armor he'd been reading about for sixteen hours, a seam below the left ribs, where the design prioritized mobility over protection. He struck once, precisely, with everything he had.

Kazran made a sound that Bás would not forget. Not of defeat, of pain, clean and human, stripped of everything else.

Then he was gone. Into the darkness, through the back of the shrine, into the forest, moving with a speed that suggested the wound had not stopped him, only redirected him.

The silence came back.

Bás stood in the debris and breathed.

Behind him, Zephyr picked himself up from the floor. There was dust in his hair and a tear in his jacket at the shoulder. He looked at Bás. Bás looked at him.

"You all right?" Bás asked.

"Mostly." Zephyr probed his ribs carefully with two fingers. "Nothing broken. You?"

"Fine."

They stood together in the ruined room, and neither of them said anything for a while. The papers from the altar had scattered in the fight, Bás's history spread across the floor of an abandoned shrine in a Japanese forest. He didn't pick it up. He left it there.

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The walk back was quieter than the walk in.

They didn't talk for the first twenty minutes. The forest released them slowly, path widening, light returning, the birds starting up again as if the disruption had been minor, local, easily forgotten. Zephyr walked with his hands behind his head, looking up through the canopy at the sky, which had gone from grey to a thin pale gold.

"I could have beaten him," he said eventually.

"You were extremely helpful," Bás said.

"That's not the same thing."

"No."

A pause.

"The files," Zephyr said. "Yours. In there." He looked sideways. "I didn't read them. I want you to know that. When I saw what they were, I put them down."

Bás absorbed this. "Thank you."

"I figure, you know my history because you've chosen to. Not because someone left papers on an altar." Zephyr shrugged, though the gesture carried more weight than he was pretending. "That's how it should work."

They emerged from the tree line onto the gravel road that led back to the village. The late afternoon light lay across everything in long horizontal bars, warm and unhurried. The cat was still on the wall. It watched them pass with unchanged equanimity.

"The izakaya," Bás said.

Zephyr stopped walking. Turned around slowly. "I'm sorry, I need to document this moment. Are you- are you voluntarily suggesting the izakaya? You? Right now?"

"I said I would."

"You did say you would." Zephyr fell back into step beside him, and Bás could hear the relief in it, the way the tension was leaving him, the way the normalcy of this small thing was doing work that no debrief could do. "All right. Good. We're going. I'm going to order everything on the menu."

"You're going to order within reason."

"I'm going to order everything on the menu."

The izakaya was small and warm and smelled like charcoal and soy and something sweet underneath. Lanterns hung from the ceiling in uneven rows. The other patrons, a group of men playing cards in the corner, a couple near the window, a lone woman reading, paid them no particular attention. Bás had learned to value that. The anonymity of an ordinary room.

They sat at the bar. Zephyr ordered. Bás allowed it.

When the food arrived, more of it than Bás would ever have chosen, skewered and grilled and presented in small ceramic dishes that seemed designed for a kind of pleasure he usually forgot to have, he ate it slowly and found that it was good.

Zephyr watched him eat with poorly concealed satisfaction.

"Don't," Bás said.

"I'm not doing anything."

"You're thinking something very loud."

Zephyr poured two small glasses of sake and slid one across. "I'm just thinking that you look approximately five percent less like a beautiful tragic statue than you did this morning, and I'm choosing to count that as a victory."

Bás looked at the glass. He picked it up.

"He's not finished," he said. "Kazran. This won't be the last time."

"Probably not." Zephyr picked up his own glass.

"I hurt him today. Not just physically. He got close to something, through the files, through knowing us, and then the conversation pushed back, and that hurt him too. People in that state are unpredictable."

"Are you worried about him?" Zephyr asked. The question was genuine, not a challenge.

Bás considered it. The honest answer was more complicated than he knew how to say. He was worried about Kazran the way you worry about something that mirrors you, not because it threatens you, but because you understand its logic too well to be comfortable.

"I think he could still choose differently," he said finally. "I think the choice is still there. I don't know if he'll take it."

Zephyr nodded slowly. He raised his glass.

"To the possibility," he said. "And to complicated enemies, and uncomfortable missions, and this-" he gestured at the food, the lanterns, the warm ordinary room, "-which is better than anything we deserve tonight."

Bás raised his glass.

"To the possibility," he agreed.

They drank.

Somewhere outside, on the street, a shadow crossed the entrance to the izakaya and kept moving. It might have been a local, heading home late. It might have been the wind moving something at the edge of vision. Bás glanced toward it without turning his head, a habit so ingrained it was almost unconscious.

Then he turned back to the food, and to Zephyr, who was already ordering a second round with the cheerful certainty of someone who has decided that being alive is, on balance, worth celebrating.

The night was not over. The mission was not finished. Kazran was somewhere in the dark outside, wounded and unreconstructed, carrying fourteen years of unanswered weight.

But that was tomorrow.

Tonight, there was sake and grilled things and lantern light and the specific, irreplaceable comfort of a person who knew your history and had chosen to stay anyway.

Bás ate his food.

It was enough.

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Is this the end?

Or only the beginning of something larger?

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